The Art of (Not) Running Away
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The Art of (Not) Running Away

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Summary

Dragged back by the fate of his destiny, Mydei is determined to escape —until Phainon quite literally sweeps him off his feet.

Or in which Mydei runs for his life, gets caught, and is forced to reevaluate his choices while being princess-carried against his will.

Notes

This was hell to post, I accidentally did it on the rich text instead of the html and didn’t notice till last second where I had to spend like 30 minutes fixing it😭

Anyways, Achilles dressing as a women to get away from his responsibilities is my Roman Empire

See the end of the work for more notes

The throne of Castrum Kremnos was not meant to be comfortable. It was carved from the black rocks of the mountains and the blood of countless warriors who once sat on it, unyielding, built to remind its occupant that a king did not sit to rest, but to command.

Mydei did not rest.

He sat with his back straight, one gauntlet covered arm resting on the iron pommel of his ceremonial sword, his gaze distant as the council droned on about matters he barely heard. He was here, as a king should be, but his mind was elsewhere—on the battlefield, in the depths of the arena where he had carved his name into history with blood and steel.

Two years. That was how long he had worn this crown.

Two years since he had split Nikador's divinity and watched the god's molten ichor spill across the sands. Since he had felt the Titan's Coreflame burn through his body, branding itself into the marrow of his bones. Since the people of Kremnos, warriors to the last, had roared his name in victory and hailed him as their God of Strife.

A title he had never sought, yet one he bore regardless.

And now, all of it—the battles, the sacrifices, the throne he bled for—meant nothing.

Because the Chrysos heirs had come for him.

They had come before, of course. When he was still a prince, still a general, they had sought him out with empty words and grand promises. Some had flattered, others had challenged, believing they could tempt or force him into joining their sacred Flame Chase.

He had turned them all away.

Castrum Kremnos fights for no one but itself, he had told them, cold and dismissive. *If you wish for battle, then draw your blade and die at my feet.*

They stopped coming after he became king. Perhaps they thought he had made his stance clear. Perhaps they thought he would come to them when he was ready.

Then, like a fool, he slew a god and took its fire.

The Flame Chase was their holy pilgrimage, a journey spanning lands and generations, where those of divine blood sought to reclaim the scattered Coreflames of the Titans. No heir had ever gathered one alone before. It had always been a shared burden, a collective effort of many hands reaching toward the same impossible prize.

Until Mydei.

He had not meant to do it. Nikador had fallen by his hand because he stood in the way, not because Mydei sought his power. But the flame had sunk into him nonetheless, and now the Chrysos heirs would not ignore him. Could not ignore him. He had done what they had all been born to do, and in doing so, he had bound himself to their cause.

He did not care.

Let them talk of fate and legacy. Let them pretend they had the right to command him. Mydei had never bowed to the gods; he would not start now.

A sharp knock echoed through the hall.

Mydei barely glanced up. The council fell silent, their murmured discussions stalling as one of the guards strode forward.

“My king,” the soldier said, fist pressed to his chest in salute. “A guest has arrived.”

Not a guest. A claimant.

Mydei exhaled through his nose. He knew who it would be before the doors even opened.

The great bronze doors swung wide.

A lone figure stepped inside, flanked by nothing but the dying light of day.

Aglaea moved with the steady grace of a woman who had never needed to rush, whose every step was measured and assured. She was clad in dark leathers, a rare sight compared to her usual garments, with a heavy traveling cloak draped over her shoulders, her sword strapped to her back in a sheath of silver and gold. She carried no banner, no sigil, yet she had no need for such things.

Golden blood ran in her veins, as it did in his.

When she spoke, her voice was soft, yet it carried through the chamber with quiet authority.

“Mydeimos, King of Castrum Kremnos.”

He did not rise. “Aglaea.”

The faintest curve of her lips. Not quite a smile. More an acknowledgment. “It has been some time.”

“Not long enough.”

She took another step forward. The guards tensed. His council exchanged uneasy glances. Mydei remained still, fingers drumming idly against the pommel of his sword.

“I will not waste your time,” Aglaea said. “You know why I am here.”

A sigh built in his chest. He swallowed it down. “Leave.”

“I cannot.”

“You *will*.” He did not raise his voice, did not need to. He was king here. His word was law.

But Aglaea only studied him with something like patience, like she had expected this response and had already planned for it.

“You have taken a Coreflame,” she said. “That cannot be ignored.”

“I did not *take* anything.” His tone cooled. “It was forced upon me.”

“And yet, it is yours now.”

Mydei clenched his jaw. He had dealt with Aglaea before, but this time, she had the weight of inevitability on her side.

“You are of Chrysos blood,” she continued. “You always have been. You were born to walk this path, whether you intended to or not.”

His grip tightened. “Do not speak to me of birthright.”

“Then let us speak of duty.”

He laughed, short and sharp. “Duty? My duty is to my kingdom.”

“Your duty is to *more* than this kingdom.”

There it was. The same arrogance all the heirs carried, the belief that their mission outweighed the rest of the world.

Aglaea took another step forward. “We have waited long enough. The heirs gather. The journey begins. And you—” she tilted her head slightly, watching him with those sharp golden eyes “—will come with us.”

Mydei rose from his throne. His voice dropped into something cold, quiet, dangerous.

“I will not.”

A silence stretched between them.

Then Aglaea smiled.

Not condescending. Not cruel.

Knowing.

She exhaled, as if he were a particularly difficult opponent in a sparring match, one she had already mapped out a dozen ways to defeat.

“You will.”

She did not press him further. She did not draw a weapon, did not order soldiers to seize him. Because she *knew*.

She knew she did not have to.

She had already won.

Mydei’s stomach twisted.

He could dismiss her. He could challenge her. He could throw her from this hall and make it clear that Castrum Kremnos was his.

And she would come back. Again. And again. And again.

She would strip him down piece by piece, not with force, but with inevitability.

His mind raced.

There was no escaping this, was there?

Unless…

No. That was absurd.

And yet.

Mydei clenched his fists, pulse thundering in his ears.

He had fought countless battles. Stood against the strongest warriors, endured the blood and the fire. And yet, the thought of facing Aglaea’s relentless certainty made something in him balk.

There was only one way out of this.

A *tactical retreat.*

His dignity could burn.

"…Very well," he said at last, sitting back down. "Leave me for now."

Aglaea studied him for a long moment, then nodded. "I will return soon."

The doors shut behind her.

The council hesitated.

They had seen their king fight through worse. They had seen him defy death itself.

And yet, as they watched Mydei press a hand over his face in resignation, they saw something rare.

Defeat.

And they would never let him live it down.

The decision to flee came slowly. The act itself happened all at once.

Mydei had faced wars, led legions, and slain gods. He had never, in all his years, entertained the thought of retreat. Yet, here he was, abandoning his throne like a coward in the dead of night.

It was a *tactical maneuver,* he told himself. Not cowardice. Not surrender.

But no matter how many times he repeated it, the truth was undeniable—he was running.

And worse, he was running in *this*.

Mydei scowled as he fastened the final clasp on the wretched garment draped over his body. The silk was too soft, too fine against his skin, and the weight of the layered skirts felt more like shackles than fabric. His usual

armor had been stripped away, replaced with something delicate and flowing, meant to mask the broadness of his shoulders and the sharp angles of his body.

A thick woolen cloak concealed most of the details, the hood drawn low over his face to shadow his features. Still, the unfamiliar weight of earrings brushed against his jaw, and the faint scent of lavender and crushed iris—an old courtly fragrance he had reluctantly doused himself in—clung to him like mockery.

No one would look at him and see Mydei, King of Castrum Kremnos.

That was the point.

He exhaled sharply, adjusting the length of his sleeves. They were too long, meant to disguise the callouses on his hands, the old scars carved into his knuckles. Every inch of him had been meticulously altered, his usually short, controlled hair now pinned and draped in a manner that felt ridiculous.

He loathed every second of this.

Yet, it was necessary.

Because if Aglaea came back—and she *would*—she would not leave without him.

He had thought, perhaps, that sheer force of will could drive her away. That if he refused her with enough finality, if he made it clear he had no interest in her sacred mission, she would abandon the endeavor.

But Aglaea was not a woman who accepted *no* as an answer.

She did not fight battles with steel and strength alone. She wielded inevitability like a blade, patience sharper than any sword. If Mydei stood his ground, she would outlast him. If he met her in battle, she would return twice as prepared. If he sealed the gates of Kremnos itself, she would wait outside them until the weight of her presence alone forced him to yield.

There was no defeating her in the way he knew best.

And so, he had done the only thing left to him.

He had *vanished*.

Or rather, he was in the process of vanishing.

Voreion was far to the north, a quiet province by the sea, known for its monasteries and its distance from anything of importance. It was a place of retreat, of those who wished to fade into obscurity. If there was anywhere he could go to outlast Aglaea's hunt, it was there.

But first, he had to leave the city.

He stepped forward, only to nearly trip on the hem of his damnable skirts.

A muscle in his jaw twitched.

Warriors do not wear skirts because skirts are not made for battle, he thought grimly. If someone drew a blade on him now, he would not even be able to move properly.

Not that he was planning to fight anyone. He was in *disguise*. Fighting would defeat the entire point.

Still, the thought of this miserable fabric impeding his movement, of how *vulnerable* it made him feel, set his teeth on edge. It was humiliating enough that he had to flee—must he also do so like *this*?

He took another step. This time, he moved slower, more deliberate. He could do this. He *had* to do this.

With that in mind, he squared his shoulders (or at least, attempted to do so in a way that did not immediately shatter the illusion of his disguise) and stepped into the streets.

If he could endure war, he could endure this.

…Probably.

The road to Voreion was long, and Mydei had never felt more suffocated in his life.

The moment he left Kremnos, he became something *less*—less imposing, less commanding, *less himself*. He hunched his shoulders beneath his heavy cloak, kept his strides deliberately measured, resisted the instinct to meet the eyes of those around him with the cold, steady weight of a warrior's gaze.

Be small. Be silent.

A task far more grating than any battlefield wound.

He had stolen away before dawn, slipping past the city gates with the ease of someone who knew its every hidden path. Walking would take him to Voreion, but *walking* meant exposure. And so, against all of his better instincts, he had taken the next, most agonizing step in his deception—he had *hired transport.*

The merchant caravan he had found was bound for the northern provinces, its carts filled with fabrics and spices, its travelers a mix of traders and pilgrims. A group of unremarkable people heading toward an unremarkable place.

Perfect.

Or at least, *it should have been.*

Mydei sat stiffly at the back of the cart, pressed against a stack of bundled linens, his hood drawn low as he pretended not to exist.

It was proving to be more difficult than expected.

The old woman sitting across from him had been staring for far too long.

He resisted the urge to shift. He knew what she saw—someone too tall, too broad, their face kept too carefully in shadow. Suspicious, perhaps. But no

one in their right mind would assume *this* was Mydei, King of Kremnos, God of Strife.

Still, her gaze burned like an itch between his shoulder blades.

“Where are you from, dear?” she finally asked.

Mydei did not answer.

He could *not* answer.

His voice was a betrayer, a deep, cutting thing that would shatter the illusion in an instant.

He had tried speaking softer before he left, had forced himself to murmur words in the quiet of his chambers just to see if he could make them passably delicate. He had lasted all of five minutes before nearly gouging a hole into the table out of sheer frustration.

Silence was safer.

So he merely bowed his head in the vaguest possible acknowledgment, hoping it would be enough.

The old woman hummed, unbothered. “Not much of a talker, are you?”

He inclined his head again, praying she would lose interest.

She did not.

“That’s good,” she said approvingly. “A woman should be reserved. Men like that.”

Mydei suddenly wished for death.

Or perhaps, not his own—*hers*.

He clenched his jaw, focusing intently on the road beyond the cart.

She must have taken his silence as encouragement because she leaned in conspiratorially. “Are you traveling to meet a husband, then?”

Mydei felt his soul forcibly exit his body.

“…I see,” she continued, mistaking his horrified stillness for something else entirely. “You must be nervous. Don’t worry, dear. I’m sure he’ll be a fine man.”

He was going to *perish*. Right here. In the back of a merchant cart.

He could not respond. Could not correct her without damning himself further.

And so he remained utterly, painfully silent.

The old woman patted his knee sympathetically. “I had an arranged match myself, you know. It’s frightening, but you’ll adjust in time.”

Mydei had never wanted to stab someone more in his entire life.

Mydei forced himself to exhale slowly, gripping the edge of his cloak with white-knuckled restraint.

This was *fine*.

He had endured sieges, assassinations, the howling madness of the battlefield. He could endure this.

But every instinct in his body rebelled against it.

The old woman’s words felt so alien to him that he nearly reeled from them. In Kremnos, women were not expected to be silent, nor were they delicate things meant to shrink in the presence of men. They commanded legions, ruled cities, and struck down those who dared question their strength.

The last Kremnoan queen had shattered an entire warfront with her bare hands.

Yet here he sat, listening to this frail, well-meaning elder talk about *obedience* as if it were a virtue, as if the kind of women Mydei had known and fought beside would ever submit to such a thing.

It was so utterly bizarre that, for a brief moment, his anger dimmed beneath the weight of sheer disbelief.

He should not be listening to this. He should not *care*.

But he had spent too many years on the battlefield, too many years knowing that a warrior was a warrior, regardless of the form they took. This was an unfamiliar world, one he had no desire to understand.

And so, for the sake of his own dignity, he kept his mouth shut.

The road stretched onward. The conversation, mercifully, did not.

Eventually, the old woman grew tired of his silence and turned her attention elsewhere. Mydei kept himself pressed against the linen bundles, feigning sleep whenever another traveler so much as glanced his way.

By the time the caravan slowed near a resting point, he had made his decision.

He needed to leave.

The ride had served its purpose, but if he stayed any longer, someone *would* try to make him speak. And if he was forced into that position, he would rather throw himself into a ravine than play this charade any further.

So the moment the carts rolled to a stop, he swung his legs over the side, landing lightly on the dirt road.

A few travelers barely spared him a glance, already stretching their limbs after the long journey.

Good.

With careful, measured steps, he adjusted the drape of his cloak, straightened his posture, and disappeared into the thinning crowd.

He will make it to Voreion.

And if he had any say in it, no one—not Aglaea, not the Chrysos heirs, *no one*—would find him there.

The caravan had taken him far enough from Kremnos that the scent of the sea had begun to sharpen in the wind, but Voreion was still distant. He had intended to continue on foot, following the quieter roads, avoiding the scrutiny of watchful eyes.

But as dusk settled, the road did not remain empty.

Travelers thickened along the path, moving toward the walled city rising in the distance.

It was not a large city, not a place of grand significance. But it was civilization—one he would need to pass through if he wanted supplies, shelter, or even the barest moment of rest before continuing north.

Which brought him to his current predicament.

How in all the hells was he supposed to get inside?

Approaching as a warrior was out of the question. A lone man, built like a war god, armed to the teeth, and traveling with no stated purpose would only draw suspicion. But the alternative—playing his role as the meek traveler, slipping through under the guise of silence—felt even more unbearable.

He exhaled, adjusting the hood of his cloak as he fell into step behind a small procession of pilgrims nearing the city gates.

It was a risk.

But all things in life were.

The guards at the entrance were unremarkable. Tired men, barely interested in the travelers filtering through. They let most pass with little more than a glance, stopping only to question those who carried visible arms.

Mydei forced himself to loosen his shoulders, to tuck his chin as if the weight of the world was not something he had carried before.

The woman ahead of him spoke in low, hurried tones, answering whatever routine inquiries the guards had.

Then it was his turn.

One of the men flicked a glance in his direction. “Purpose of travel?”

Mydei hesitated—just for a breath, just long enough that the man narrowed his gaze in mild impatience.

Think.

He could not claim pilgrimage, nor could he pass as a merchant. His hands were too calloused, his posture too firm. But there was one thing he had observed during his miserable time in the caravan.

Some travelers were not alone.

He turned, casting a quick glance toward the elderly woman still making her way through the checkpoint.

Then, with all the conviction of a man resigned to humiliation, he took a step closer to her.

The movement was subtle. Just enough that, to an untrained eye, it would seem like they were together.

The woman blinked at him in confusion—then, as if piecing something together, she smiled.

“My granddaughter and I are visiting family,” she told the guard smoothly. “Poor thing hasn’t been feeling well. You understand.”

The guard barely looked at Mydei after that.

“Go on, then,” he muttered, waving them through.

Mydei did not breathe until they were well past the gates.

And then—

“Granddaughter?” he rasped.

The woman patted his arm affectionately. “It was the least I could do, dear.”

He stared at her in abject horror.

This was fine. This was still *fine*.

All he had to do was endure.

Voreion was waiting, he repeated in his head like mantra.

He turned to the old woman—the same one who, with a mere sentence, had effortlessly cleared the obstacle he had spent far too long agonizing over.

“…Thank you,” he forced out, his voice just above a whisper.

The woman smiled. “Think nothing of it, dear.”

And with that, she patted his arm once more and *walked away*, completely unaware that she had just saved the dignity—and quite possibly the life—of the God of Strife himself.

Mydei remained standing there for a moment, watching as she disappeared into the crowd, before dragging a hand down his face.

Fine.

He was in.

Now all he had to do was keep his head down, find supplies, and make his way to that damned island before anyone caught on.

After all, Mydei was *almost* free.

His plan had been simple—get what he needed, avoid unnecessary attention, and leave the city before his luck ran dry. He had maneuvered through the streets with precision, keeping his stride measured, his head lowered, his presence unremarkable.

Then he felt it.

A shift in the air.

A presence so familiar that his body reacted before his mind could catch up.

He went still.

For a warrior like him, recognition was instinctive. The way someone walked, the way they carried themselves—these things could not be mistaken.

And there, across the market square, standing among the sea of strangers—

Phainon.

The Deliverer of Okhema.

The one person in the entire world he *did not* want to see.

Mydei's soul nearly left his body.

His first thought was that this was a cruel joke. His second was that he must be hallucinating. But no, Phainon was *right there*, speaking to a merchant with the same composed, charismatic expression Mydei had seen a thousand times before.

For a single, horrifying moment, he was back on the battlefield.

Their spars had always been wordless affairs—sharp, precise, efficient. Phainon's movements were like clockwork, relentless yet deliberate. Mydei had always respected that about him. Admired it, even.

They had never spoken much beyond what was necessary. They had met as warriors, as kings, as men of purpose.

And yet, despite the formality of their relationship, Mydei had *liked* him.

Not as a friend. Not as a rival. But as something else, something neither of them had ever acknowledged.

And now?

Now, instead of standing before Phainon as an equal, Mydei was standing there *draped in lace and silk, hiding behind perfume and pretense like a coward.*

The sheer humiliation of it sent a fresh wave of fury down his spine.

No.

He clenched his jaw, forcing his breath to steady.

No, he will not recognize me.

He had spent years perfecting the art of control, of making himself unreadable. If he could withstand the eyes of gods and kings, he could withstand this.

And so, with all the grace of a hunted man, Mydei adjusted his veil, turned sharply on his heel—

And walked in the opposite direction as fast as humanly possible.

Mydei had nearly made it to the alleyway when disaster struck.

A passing merchant jostled into him, nothing more than a brief, careless bump.

Under normal circumstances, this would have been nothing. Mydei had taken spear thrusts to the ribs without so much as a stumble.

But these were not normal circumstances.

His borrowed sandals, *damn them*, had been too delicate from the start. And as his foot caught on the uneven cobblestone, his balance—his hard-earned, battle-tested balance—betrayed him.

He tripped.

For a single, horrifying moment, the world tilted. Mydei flailed, twisting mid-fall to catch himself before he could completely eat the street like a fool. But before he could even brace for impact—

A steady hand caught him by the arm.

Warm. Strong. Unmistakable.

Mydei barely had time to process the sheer luck of avoiding utter mortification before the voice followed.

“Are you alright?”

His blood turned to ice.

No. No, no, no.

Slowly, stiffly, he looked up—

And found himself staring into Phainon’s face.

Up close, nothing had changed about him. The same sharp, regal features. The same quiet composure. The same steady gaze that had once measured him in the heat of battle.

But this time, that gaze held something else.

Concern.

Kindness.

Mydei felt physically ill.

He scrambled to right himself, jerking away as if burned. “I’m fine,” he muttered, voice deliberately softer than usual, clipped and tense.

Phainon studied him, brow furrowing slightly, but he made no move to press.

“Be careful,” was all he said, before stepping back, giving Mydei space.

That should have been the end of it.

That could have been the end of it.

But fate, as always, was a merciless thing.

Phainon did not leave.

Instead, he hesitated, as if debating something.

Then, after a long pause, he asked, “Are you new to the city?”

Mydei’s stomach sank.

He had two options: answer and risk further conversation, or ignore him and seem suspicious.

Neither was ideal.

So he settled for the least disastrous one. “Passing through,” he said, keeping his voice measured, his eyes averted.

Phainon nodded, as if that was answer enough. “If you need directions, I can—”

“No,” Mydei interrupted hastily. “I know my way.”

A silence stretched between them.

Too long. Too noticeable.

Mydei dared a glance up, just enough to see Phainon regarding him with the same quiet patience Mydei remembered from their past meetings.

It burned.

They had fought together before, side by side in the unspoken understanding of warriors. Their battles had been ones of trust, of skill, of mutual respect. Phainon had once looked at him with *admiration*, not…

Not like this.

Not like Mydei was something fragile, something in need of help.

It was unbearable.

He needed to *leave*.

Mydei turned to do exactly that.

Or at least, he tried to.

Phainon, in all his composed, well-mannered persistence, was suddenly far too *helpful.*

“If you’re looking for lodging, I can recommend an inn.”

“I’m not.”

“Or if it’s supplies, the market on the west side has fair prices.”

“I know.”

“And if you’re searching for someone, I might be able to—”

“I’m not,” Mydei snapped, before catching himself.

Phainon raised a brow.

Damn it. *Damn it.*

He reined himself in, gripping the edges of his veil as if it could physically restrain his frustration. Stay calm. Be normal.

"…I mean," he amended stiffly, "I have everything I need."

Phainon didn't look entirely convinced, but he also—mercifully—didn't press. Instead, he merely inclined his head. "Then I hope your travels go well."

For the first time since this wretched encounter began, Mydei felt something akin to *relief*.

He dipped his head quickly, mumbling some vague farewell before turning once again to leave—

Only for Phainon to *move with him.*

Not blocking his way, not quite, but enough that Mydei was very aware of his continued presence.

His pulse spiked.

This was fine. This was *fine*. Phainon was just going in the same direction. Coincidence. Nothing more.

And yet, every step felt too aligned. Every glance, every shift of Phainon's head, every casual movement—it all felt too deliberate.

Did he know?

No. No, if he knew, he wouldn't be this calm. Phainon had no reason to suspect him.

Still, the man was *too* helpful. Too attentive.

A Kremnoan warlord in disguise should not have to endure this level of *hospitality*.

Mydei had stood on battlefields drenched in blood. He had fought men twice his size, endured wounds that would break lesser warriors, and faced down warlords who spoke of death like a promise.

None of it had ever tested his patience like this.

Phainon was still walking beside him, still speaking, still lingering. Mydei didn't know what cruel twist of fate had led to this moment, but he hated it.

And worse—he had to *play along*.

He had to be careful, measured. He couldn't be himself. Couldn't walk like a warrior, couldn't stand too straight, couldn't let his voice slip into the sharp edge of command. It was like wearing ill-fitted armor, heavy and restrictive in all the wrong ways.

"You must not be from here," Phainon remarked lightly. "I would have remembered seeing you before."

Mydei's stomach twisted. He kept his gaze low, his voice soft. "I haven't been here long."

Phainon hummed. "And you travel alone?"

Mydei hesitated.

A woman dressed as finely as he was—veiled, composed—would not typically be wandering without escort. And so, against every instinct, he nodded. "…Yes."

Phainon's expression didn't change, but there was a pause, like he was considering something.

Mydei braced himself.

"Then I'll accompany you a little longer," Phainon said, voice steady.

Absolutely not.

“That’s unnecessary,” Mydei said quickly, polite but firm.

Phainon didn’t quite smile, but there was something in his expression, something imperceptible.

“I insist.”

Then—

It was just a hand.

Just a hand.

And yet Mydei’s entire body locked up the moment Phainon’s fingers closed around his, a light but firm hold as he guided him toward the carriage. It was effortless, natural—the kind of thing a gentleman might do for a lady without a second thought.

Unfortunately for Mydei, he was neither a lady nor capable of not thinking about it.

His mind was a storm of curses as he walked, led like some delicate thing when he had broken men with these hands, spilled blood by the rivers. How in the gods’ names had he let it come to this?

It was *fine*, he told himself. He just had to get in the carriage, figure out where to go next, and get as far from here as possible.

And soon, he would have to. They would notice he was gone—if they hadn’t already.

North was the fastest way to Voreion, but it was also the most obvious. Too obvious. Aglaea would send hounds in that direction first.

Which meant he needed a different route.

When they reached the carriage, Mydei finally freed his hand and turned to Phainon, keeping his voice carefully even. “Would you be able to take me east? Toward the river roads?”

Phainon blinked, then let out a soft laugh. “That’s quite the coincidence. I’m headed that way myself.”

Mydei stiffened.

His immediate thought was suspicion. But then, he reminded himself—why wouldn’t Phainon have business there? It was a well-traveled route. It was only chance.

Still, he said nothing as Phainon opened the door, gesturing for him to step inside.

And then, just as Mydei moved to enter, Phainon reached for his hand again—this time, lifting it lightly, bowing his head, and pressing a brief, courteous kiss to his knuckles.

The world slowed.

It was nothing. A mere formality. A polite custom meant to flatter.

But Mydei’s breath caught in his throat as though he’d been *struck*.

His mind was blank. His body was rigid. And for a split second, all he could think—beyond the pure, unfiltered *embarrassment*—was:

I am going to kill him.

Mydei sat as rigid as a war statue, hands pressed against his lap, his expression frozen in what he *hoped* passed for a neutral, demure look instead of barely contained fury.

He needed to breathe.

In. Out.

He was Mydeimos the Undying, King of Castrum Kremnos, the God of Strife. His name was spoken in reverence and terror alike. Armies had shattered beneath his blade. Empires had redrawn their borders at his conquests.

And yet here he was. In a carriage. In silk. And he had nearly *stopped breathing* because Phainon had kissed his damn hand.

The sheer *indignity*.

Across from him, Phainon lounged easily, seemingly unaware of the catastrophic war taking place in Mydei's mind. He was relaxed, smiling faintly, one arm resting along the back of the seat.

"You seem tense," Phainon remarked after a moment, tilting his head. "Not used to travel?"

Mydei forced himself to focus. His voice, when he answered, was deliberately soft, clipped. "It is fine."

Phainon hummed. "If it's the roads, I assure you they're smooth enough past the next mile. But if it's—ah." His gaze flickered, amusement creeping into his expression. "Is it the kiss?"

Mydei felt every muscle in his body go taut.

"No," he said, too fast.

Phainon's smile widened.

"Ah, good," he said lightly. "I'd hate to think I made you uncomfortable."

Liar. He was enjoying this.

Mydei exhaled through his nose, barely restraining himself from crossing his arms. "It was unexpected," he muttered.

"A mere courtesy," Phainon said with a knowing shrug. "Though, if I'm being honest, I don't usually meet such silent women. You're rather…

different.”

Mydei was going to *strangle him.*

He schooled his expression, giving a stiff nod. “I prefer not to waste words.”

“A rare trait,” Phainon mused, watching him closely. “Though I can’t help but feel I’ve met someone like you before…”

Mydei’s heart stuttered.

He kept his gaze trained on the carriage wall, forcing out the most indifferent sound he could manage. “Many people are alike.”

Phainon made a thoughtful noise but didn’t press further.

Instead, he sighed, stretching slightly. “Well, since we have some time together, perhaps we should talk?”

Mydei’s jaw clenched. “About what?”

Phainon chuckled. “I don’t know. You tell me. You seem the type with an interesting story.”

If only he knew.

Mydei closed his eyes briefly, steeling himself. He just had to get through this. A bit of conversation, some meaningless words, and then he would be free.

He could do this.

… Probably.

Mydei scoured his mind for an unassuming story—something to throw Phainon off without raising suspicion. It had to be casual. Simple.

Unfortunately, *simple* had never been a part of his life.

He considered his options. Most of his tales ended in blood, battle, or both. But there was one…

“Once,” he began, keeping his tone light, “I met a man who thought he could kill a boar with his bare hands.”

Phainon raised a brow, interest flickering in his gaze. “And?”

“He was wrong.”

Silence. Then Phainon let out a short laugh. “You’re terrible at telling stories.”

Mydei shrugged. “It’s what happened.”

“And what happened to the man?”

“He lived,” Mydei admitted. “Barely. He was too stubborn to die.”

Phainon chuckled, shaking his head. “I swear, you remind me of someone.”

Mydei ignored the way his stomach twisted at the words and instead redirected the conversation. “What about you? Surely someone of your caliber has some tales worth telling.”

Phainon smirked. “More than I can count.”

And so he spoke.

The night stretched on, the carriage rocking in a slow, rhythmic sway. The clatter of wheels against the road, the muffled hum of conversation in the distance, the low timbre of Phainon’s voice weaving through the quiet—steady, unhurried.

Mydei hadn’t meant to sleep. He never did.

Rest had never come easily to him. Even in his own halls, he had trained himself to keep his senses sharp, his body coiled, ready to move at the

slightest disturbance. Sleep was a concession he rarely allowed.

And yet, here…

The warmth of the enclosed space, the weight of the night pressing in, the unfamiliar comfort of companionship—something in it all pulled at him, lulling him into a stillness he was unaccustomed to.

His muscles, always wound tight, began to loosen. His mind, sharp and guarded, dulled at the edges. His eyelids grew heavier with each slow breath.

He barely noticed when his body gave in, when his head tipped forward, resting against the solid warmth of Phainon's shoulder.

A pause. A quiet intake of breath. Then, a shift—Phainon adjusting ever so slightly, not pulling away, not speaking.

And then, low and quiet, as though speaking any louder would break the moment entirely—

"Rest," Phainon murmured, voice strangely familiar.

Mydei would wonder about that later.

For now, he was too tired to care.

The first thing Mydei registered upon waking was warmth. Unfamiliar, steady warmth pressed against his side, the scent of leather and something faintly spiced lingering nearby. His mind was sluggish, reluctant to pull itself from the depths of rest, and for a moment, he let himself linger in it, his body still loose from sleep.

Then, the second thing hit him—

Where the fuck am I?

His eyes snapped open. The carriage rocked gently beneath him, the early morning light spilling through the curtains, casting soft shadows across the interior. The air was cool, the faint scent of damp earth lingering after what must have been a night's rain.

Mydei jerked upright with a sharp inhale, the last traces of sleep fleeing instantly. His gaze darted around, mind scrambling through the events of last night—Phainon, the carriage, the slow drag of conversation until, against all odds, he had… *fallen asleep.* On *him*.

A flicker of mortification shot through him, but it was quickly eclipsed by something more pressing.

The roads outside.

He frowned.

These weren't the ones he had memorized.

The route should have been taking them along the river bend, the landmarks unmistakable, but what stretched beyond the carriage window now was unfamiliar—a road winding through dense woodland, thick mist curling through the trees.

He didn't recognize this path.

Mydei's stomach turned, suspicion creeping into his chest as his fingers instinctively reached for the dagger strapped beneath his borrowed skirts.

Where in the gods' names were they going?

Phainon was already watching him when Mydei turned, blue eyes catching the morning light as he smiled. "You're awake." His voice was easy, warm —too warm. "Did you sleep well?"

Mydei didn't hesitate.

Steel flashed between them in an instant, the dagger pressed flush against Phainon's throat before he could even blink.

“Where are we?” Mydei demanded, voice low, still thick from sleep but no less deadly. His grip was steady, sharp eyes locked onto Phainon’s face, waiting for a flicker of deception, of anything that would suggest betrayal.

Phainon, to his immense irritation, didn’t so much as flinch.

Instead, his gaze flicked down to the blade at his throat, then back up, his mouth curving slightly at the edges.

“You really are a sight in the morning,” Phainon mused, tilting his head as if *he* were the one observing Mydei, not the other way around. “Though I admit, I was hoping for a gentler wake-up call.”

“Phainon.”

“Mm?”

“Answer the gods-damned question.”

Phainon exhaled through his nose, still irritatingly unbothered. “Relax. We’re still on the way to the river. I simply took a different path. Less direct, but safer. Fewer prying eyes.”

Mydei didn’t lower the dagger. “You didn’t mention a different path before.”

“You didn’t ask,” Phainon replied smoothly, then smiled again—smaller this time, less teasing. “And I thought you trusted me.”

Mydei *didn’t*, not right now. But begrudgingly, he could admit the route wasn’t *entirely* suspicious. With a sharp breath, he withdrew the dagger, tucking it back into the folds of his clothes before leaning back, jaw tight.

Phainon hummed. “Good. I’d rather not start the day with a slit throat.” He rolled his shoulders, as if shaking off the near-murder like one would shake off morning stiffness. “Well, now that that’s settled—”

“You’re insufferable,” Mydei muttered.

“So I’ve been told.”

Silence stretched for a moment. The carriage rocked steadily along the road, the only sound the faint creak of wood and the distant chirping of birds. Mydei exhaled, running a hand through his hair, composing himself.

Then—

“Are you done playing around?”

It was said so softly that Mydei almost didn’t catch it.

But he did.

His head snapped up. “What?”

Phainon held his gaze, blue eyes steady and unreadable, but his tone carried unmistakable exasperation. “Enough with the act.” A brief pause. “You can stop now.”

The words were like ice down his spine.

No.

No, that wasn’t—he *couldn’t* mean—

Mydei’s brain stalled.

He stared.

Phainon stared back, waiting.

A slow, awful realization began to dawn, creeping in like rot.

He knows.

He knew the whole time.

Mydei went rigid, blood rushing to his ears. His mouth opened, then closed. His grip twitched where his hands rested on his lap, and for the first time in *years*, he was utterly at a loss.

And Phainon—Phainon had the audacity to look almost *fond.*

“You—” Mydei started, voice strangled. He swallowed, trying to gather the last scraps of his dignity, but there was none left.

“Yes?” Phainon prompted, lips twitching.

Mydei *hated* him.

Hated him more than Aglaea, more than Nikador, more than *any* of the foes he had ever faced. Because none of them had ever reduced him to *this*.

There was no coming back from this humiliation.

There was only one solution.

With all the quiet, lethal grace he possessed, Mydei stood. He adjusted his sleeves, smoothed down his skirt, and then—

“I challenge you to a death match.”

Phainon blinked.

“…What.”

Mydei *lunged*.

The moment Mydei lunged, the carriage *violently* lurched to a stop.

Then, they were airborne.

For a split second, Mydei barely had time to process what was happening before the world tilted, and he and Phainon were *launched* out of the carriage like discarded cargo. The ground rushed up to meet them, and Mydei barely twisted in time to land on his feet, skidding to a halt.

Phainon, ever so graceful, landed on his back with a dull *thud*.

The driver, an older man who had been minding his own business until now, glared down at them with the unimpressed stare of someone who had seen enough in life to not be *paid* enough for this.

“Take your lovers’ quarrel *outside* my carriage,” he huffed, then promptly snapped the reins and sped off, leaving a cloud of dust in his wake.

Silence.

Mydei stared at the rapidly disappearing carriage.

Phainon, still sprawled on the ground, blinked up at the sky, expression blank. “…Did we just get *thrown* out of a moving carriage?”

Mydei didn’t answer. He turned, posture taut, fury barely contained beneath the thin veneer of composure he still clung to.

“Wait—” Phainon started, scrambling to his feet, reaching out as if to physically stop him. “Just—just hold on a second—”

Mydei turned on him like a storm.

“No.”

Phainon took a step back. “No?”

“No. You do *not* get to ‘hold on a second’ me after that.”

“Okay, but—”

“Do not try to explain yourself.”

Phainon hesitated, looking as if he was debating the wisdom of opening his mouth. Unfortunately, he made the wrong choice.

“I wasn’t *judging* you,” he blurted in a panic. “I think you actually look quite pretty like that—”

Mydei lunged *again*.

Phainon barely had time to breathe before he was *slammed* into the dirt, his back hitting the ground so hard that the wind shot out of his lungs.

"*Come on!*" he wheezed, hands scrambling to grab Mydei's wrists before the bastard could do any more damage. He failed.

A fist connected with his shoulder, hard enough that he swore he felt the impact in his *teeth*.

"*You*—" Mydei snarled, knee pressing down against Phainon's ribs, "—*are insufferable*."

Phainon grunted, trying and *failing* to shove him off. "You are a lunatic—ow, watch the—!"

Another sharp pain shot through his arm as Mydei twisted it behind his head, pinning him down with all the weight of someone who had spent a lifetime winning wars and breaking bones.

Phainon would have made another quip—he *wanted* to, desperately—but his next breath got cut off when Mydei *moved*, his weight shifting, pressing him even further into the dirt.

Phainon froze.

Because Mydei was *straddling* him now.

His skirts, already a damn mess from the scuffle, had been torn, the long fabric abandoned in jagged shreds around them. Mydei had *ripped* them apart like they were nothing, prioritizing mobility over modesty, and the effect was… *something*.

Mostly terrifying.

Definitely humiliating.

Phainon, thoroughly *pinned*, let out a strangled sound that was definitely not dignified.

“Okay,” he wheezed, still struggling uselessly under Mydei’s grip, “I can *explain*—”

Mydei leaned in just slightly, grip tightening around Phainon’s wrists, expression still thunderous.

Phainon stared up at him, the weight of him, the absolute *fury* in his eyes, the sheer *absurdity* of this situation.

Then, helplessly, he started laughing.

Mydei’s glare could have *skinned* a man alive.

“What,” he spat, voice low and full of venom, “is so *funny*?”

Phainon, despite *everything*—despite the dirt in his hair, the bruises forming on his arms, the absolute degradation of being straddled and *immobilized*—grinned up at him through the pain.

“You,” he wheezed, voice breathy from exertion. “You’re—” He coughed, laughing again, “—so much *prettier* when you’re trying to kill me.”

If looks could kill, Mydei would have committed war crimes.

Any *ounce* of feminine grace he had been imitating was *gone*. The delicate gestures, the careful restraint, the poised silence—all of it had been *shattered* the moment his rage took over. His muscles, no longer hidden beneath flowing fabric, were out in the open, coiled with years of battle-forged strength.

He was not a lady.

He was not delicate.

He was *Mydeimos of Kremnos*, and he had just pinned the Deliverer of Okhema to the fucking *ground*.

Phainon, an idiot, was still smiling.

Mydei's grip on his wrists tightened, and for a moment, he actually considered breaking a bone just to *shut him up.*

But then the realization hit him.

His breath stilled.

If Phainon was here—if he had found him—then that meant…

Aglaea.

His stomach *plummeted*.

And if Phainon and Aglaea, both Chrysos heirs, were here, then—

No. No, no, no

They had come to *drag* him to Okhema.

To *join* them.

And Mydei—Mydei, the King of Kremnos, the *Undying*, the one who had led wars and conquered battlefields—had just *disgraced* himself so thoroughly that he genuinely wondered if it was too late to change his *nationality*.

He had pinned the Deliverer of Okhema to the ground. While disguised as a woman. In a ripped dress.

He was going to throw up.

Absolute *shame* coursing through him, Mydei moved to get off—*roughly*, pushing himself up as quickly as possible.

He needed to leave.

But before he could, Phainon's damnably strong grip latched onto his arm, yanking him back down with ease.

Mydei *choked* on his own breath as he was forcibly pulled back onto Phainon, his balance thrown, his escape utterly thwarted.

His arm strength. Damn his arm strength.

Mydei thrashed like a *wild animal.*

His body twisted, his legs kicked, his nails dug into Phainon's arms as he wrenched against the grip holding him down.

"Let. Me. Go." His voice was poison, sharp as a dagger's edge. "Unhand me, *you Chrysos bastard!"*

Phainon, unbothered, only tightened his grip.

"Not so fast." His voice was calm, almost amused—which only made Mydei's fury worse.

Mydei bucked, *snarling* when Phainon held firm, his grip unshakable. He twisted his wrist, dug his nails into the sensitive skin beneath Phainon's thumb, kicked out his leg in an attempt to knee him—but Phainon didn't let go.

He barely even reacted.

Golden blood trickled down Phainon's arm where Mydei's nails had torn through skin. A bruise was already forming where Mydei had landed a sharp elbow to his ribs.

And yet—he did not loosen his grip.

Even when Mydei raked his nails down his forearm—*nothing*.

Even when Mydei slammed his knee into his side—*nothing*.

Phainon exhaled, only slightly strained. "You done?"

Mydei hissed like a cornered cat and bit his arm.

Phainon *winced* this time, his grip faltering for just a second.

But still—he didn't let go.

"…Alright," Phainon muttered, voice slightly pained. "That one *hurt*."

Mydei stilled just enough to spit out his next words, voice *raw* with defiance.

"I am not going to Okhema." His breath was ragged, anger dripping from every syllable. "You'll have to drag me there in chains."

Phainon exhaled through his nose.

Of course.

He looked down at his bruised arm, at the faint crescent-shaped wounds where Mydei's teeth had sunk in. Then back at Mydei himself—still *thrashing*, still *furious*, still burning with the stubborn pride of a Kremnoan warrior.

Phainon sighed. Long. Slow. Tired.

"Right," he muttered. "Should've seen that one coming."

The moment Phainon's grip *shifted*, Mydei moved.

He barely loosened, barely *slipped* his arms free—but it was enough. His foot dug into the dirt, ready to launch himself forward—

Only for the world to *tilt.*

"Alright, buddy," Phainon sighed again, voice far too casual for someone who had just *bodily lifted* a full-grown warrior king off the ground.

Mydei's breath stopped.

For the first time since this miserable encounter began, he was *stunned* into silence.

Phainon had him princess-carried.

Arms under his legs and back, like some delicate noble, and worst of all—effortlessly.

Phainon just… started *walking*.

“You—” Mydei’s brain nearly shut down. “Put me down.”

Phainon, very *pointedly*, did not.

Mydei’s body tensed, coiled like a beast ready to tear into Phainon’s throat.

The humiliation, the audacity—he didn’t care if Phainon was stronger, if he had the advantage, if he was a damn good fighter. Mydei would make him regret this.

He twisted, ready to slam his elbow into Phainon’s ribs, to claw his way free, to win—

“Mydei.”

Phainon’s voice was different.

Not light. Not teasing. Not mocking.

Serious. Steady. Undeniable.

“You have to go,” Phainon said. “Whether you like it or not.”

Mydei froze.

“You’re a Chrysos heir. The inheritor of Nikador’s Coreflame. You don’t have a choice, this is your responsibility and yours alone.”

The words dug into him, sharp and final.

And just as suddenly, the fight drained from his body all at once.

Because Phainon was right.

As much as he wanted to deny it, to reject it, to keep running—he couldn’t.

Not just because of Phainon.

Not just because of Aglaea.

But because of who he was.

Because of the title bound to him by birth, because of the legacy that had hunted him down even after he had abandoned it.

He was Mydei a Chrysos Heir as much as he was Mydeimos, a Son of Kremnos.

He had always known he would be dragged back into the flame someday.

His body slumped. The tension left his limbs, his fingers uncurling from where they had been ready to claw at Phainon’s skin.

He let his head drop back, his gaze unfocused, blank.

Fine.

Let them take him.

Let them drag him back in chains or silk, whatever they pleased.

It didn’t matter anymore.

Phainon stilled, his grip steady, but Mydei felt the slight hitch in his step—the barely perceptible hesitation.

“…Huh,” Phainon muttered after a moment, his voice quiet but with a hint of surprise. “Didn’t think that would work.”

Mydei exhaled sharply, not quite a laugh, not quite anything.

He closed his eyes.

And let himself be carried.

The weight of resignation settled in Mydei's chest like stone. There was no point in struggling anymore. He would go. He had no other choice.

Phainon carried him in silence, their footsteps crunching against the dirt path. Mydei kept his gaze fixed ahead, his body lax but his mind whirring. His fate was sealed, and all he could do now was brace for what awaited him in Okhema.

A few minutes passed before Phainon shifted slightly. Mydei felt it before he heard it—an almost hesitant adjustment of his grip, like he was working up the nerve to speak.

"…We don't have to go straight to Okhema," Phainon said, voice uncharacteristically cautious. "There's a river nearby. It's beautiful this time of year."

Mydei's gaze flickered to him. He knew what this was—one last moment of fleeting comfort before the inevitable. A delay, nothing more. He should've refused.

But to his own surprise, he didn't.

"…Fine," he muttered, and Phainon stopped walking.

Without a word, Phainon carefully set him down, his movements slow, as if he expected Mydei to lash out at any moment. He didn't. He merely stood there, arms crossed, gaze unreadable.

Then Phainon shrugged off his outer layer—a thick, warm cover worn over his tunic. He held it out, not pushing, just offering. "If you want," he said simply.

Mydei stared at it for a second. He didn't move.

Phainon didn’t wait for an answer. He turned and started walking toward the river, trusting Mydei to follow.

Mydei exhaled sharply, then—swift as a shadow—he grabbed the cover, draping it over himself before stepping after Phainon without a word.

Phainon, oblivious to Mydei’s gaze burning into his back, continued talking as they walked.

“I think you’ll like Okhema,” he said, voice lighter now, as if he were trying to reassure Mydei as much as himself. “There’s this bakery near the main square—best honey cakes you’ll ever have. And the libraries, Mydei, you have no idea. I’ll take you to the one near the gardens, you’ll love it—”

Phainon kept talking, his voice animated, genuine.

He didn’t notice Mydei’s pace slow for just a fraction of a second.

Didn’t notice the way Mydei adjusted the cover slightly over himself, as if the warmth had finally settled in.

And he certainly didn’t notice the way Mydei’s ears burned red as he followed from behind.

End Notes

Hmmmm, what’re we thinking abt a sacrificial lamb au? Asking for a friend😍

Anyway thank u for reading <333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!